MODULE 13 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Engaging stakeholders and managing expectations

Turning analysis into engagement, building trust and influence, surfacing hidden expectations, and keeping customers satisfied.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 13 of 49

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Satisfaction is what was delivered,
compared with what was expected.

The engagement cycle

01

Identify

Find stakeholders and analyse them.

02

Plan engagement

Decide how to move each towards the engagement needed.

03

Manage engagement

Carry out the plan: meet, involve, respond.

04

Monitor engagement

Check whether it is working, and adjust.

ON THE EXAM

Engagement is a cycle, not a launch event. Stakeholders' positions change, so the plan must too.

The stakeholder engagement plan

- For each stakeholder or group: **current and desired engagement**, from the assessment matrix.
- **Strategies and actions** to close the gap: meetings, involvement in decisions, demonstrations.
- **Who** engages them, and how often.
- Some parts are sensitive, just like the register. Share it with judgement.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The engagement plan says how to change engagement. The communications plan says how to move information.

Building trust

- **Consistency**: do what you said you would, especially small things.
- **Transparency**: share the real status, including problems.
- **Bad news early**, with facts and options. Never let a stakeholder be surprised.
- **Listen** more than you present, and show that what you heard changed something.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Trust is built in small, kept promises and lost in one hidden problem.

Influencing without authority

- Start from **their interests**: what does this stakeholder need, and fear?
- Use **evidence**: data, pilots and demonstrations persuade better than argument.
- **Involve** them in shaping decisions. People support what they helped create.
- Build **allies**: people they already trust can carry the message.
- Pressure through their manager wins compliance, and loses trust.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Influence starts with understanding the other person. Pressure is the last tool, not the first.

Requirements or expectations?

REQUIREMENTS

Stated and agreed

- Written down and approved
- Testable against acceptance criteria
- Change through the agreed process
- What the project must deliver

EXPECTATIONS

Often unstated

- Assumptions in people's heads
- Include 'obvious' things nobody wrote
- Shift as people learn and talk
- How the result will be judged

THE TIEBREAKER

A project can meet every requirement and still disappoint. The gap is unstated expectations.

Surfacing expectations early

- Ask directly: 'What would make you say this project succeeded? What would disappoint you?'
- Use **prototypes, mock-ups and demonstrations**. People react to things more reliably than to documents.
- Write down **assumptions** and confirm them. An assumption log is an expectations log.
- Revisit expectations as the project learns. They move, even when requirements do not.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Show something early. A prototype surfaces expectations that no interview will.

When stakeholders expect different things

- Bring them together and make the **conflict and trade-offs visible**.
- Anchor on the **project objectives and business case**, not on who is loudest.
- Use prioritisation techniques to find a sequence that serves both, such as an MVP first.
- The decision belongs to the **sponsor or product owner**. The PM facilitates it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Facilitate alignment. Do not quietly pick a side, and do not promise everyone everything.

Internal or external customers?

INTERNAL CUSTOMERS

Inside the organisation

- Departments that receive the output
- Operations teams who will run it
- Colleagues depending on your deliverable
- Judged by fitness for their work

EXTERNAL CUSTOMERS

Outside the organisation

- Clients and end users
- Paying customers of a product
- Partners and the public
- Judged by value, experience and contract

THE TIEBREAKER

Both have expectations the outline asks you to monitor. Operations teams are customers too.

Monitoring satisfaction

METHOD	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Reviews and demonstrations	Direct reactions to real work, every iteration
Surveys and satisfaction scores	Trends over time, across many people
Usage and support data	What people actually do, not what they say
One-to-one conversations	The concerns people will not raise in a group
Informal signals	Tone of emails, attendance, questions that stop being asked

ON THE EXAM

Monitor, then respond. A satisfaction measure nobody acts on is just a report.

Gold plating is not managing expectations

- **Gold plating**: adding features or quality the customer did not ask for, hoping to delight.
- It adds cost, risk and testing, and quietly resets expectations for next time.
- Deliver what was agreed. If an extra is valuable, propose it through the change process or the backlog.
- Exceed expectations by delivering **reliably and transparently**, not by surprise additions.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Unrequested extras are a scope problem, not a gift. Route good ideas through the proper channel.

Expectations on agile projects

- **Frequent reviews** keep expectations and reality close, every iteration.
- A visible **backlog and roadmap** show what is coming, and what is not.
- Explain early that **scope is adaptive**: dates and budgets may be fixed while features flex.
- A stakeholder who expects every original idea delivered will be disappointed by a successful agile project.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Agile manages expectations by showing work often. Set the expectation that scope will adapt, at the start.

Delivering bad news

- **Early**: as soon as you know, even before you have a full recovery plan.
- **Factual**: what happened, what is known, what is not yet known.
- **With next steps**: options being assessed, and when you will report back.
- Waiting until you have a perfect plan lets the stakeholder hear it from someone else.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> No surprises. Share what you know now, and when you will know more.

Keeping the sponsor engaged

- The sponsor **champions** the project, provides **funding**, makes key **decisions**, and resolves issues beyond the PM's authority.
- Agree early how the sponsor wants to be engaged: format, frequency, decision thresholds.
- Bring decisions, not just information: options, a recommendation, and the deadline.
- A disengaged sponsor is a serious risk. Address it directly, with the sponsor, first.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Sponsor engagement is a key concept in PMBOK 8. A disengaged sponsor is the PM's problem to raise.

Project Lantern: engagement in action

- **Clinic managers**, resistant: each co-designs their clinic's go-live checklist.
- **Reception staff**: see prototypes early, and their feedback visibly changes the screens.
- **Patients**: a panel tests each release; satisfaction and usage are tracked from the first clinic.
- **Sponsor**: a fortnightly thirty-minute decision meeting, with options prepared in advance.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Different stakeholders, different engagement. Each action is chosen to close a specific gap.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Requirements met, customer still unhappy	Unstated expectations: surface them early with prototypes
Two stakeholders want opposite things	Facilitate trade-offs against objectives; right person decides
Team added unrequested features	Gold plating: deliver what was agreed; route extras properly
Sponsor missing meetings, decisions stalled	Meet the sponsor; agree how they want to engage
A delay is coming; no plan yet	Tell stakeholders now, with facts and when options follow
Product owner happy, users are not	Get direct user feedback and usage data

ON THE EXAM

Close the gap between expected and delivered, early and often. That is expectation management.

> A customer formally accepted a new booking website that meets every documented requirement. A week later, the customer complains that it works poorly on mobile phones.
>
> Mobile use was never written into the requirements. The customer says it was 'obviously' expected.

What should the project manager have done to prevent this?

A Surfaced and confirmed expectations early, including unstated ones, using prototypes and demonstrations.

B Written a more detailed contract that excluded anything not listed.

C Added mobile support at no charge as soon as the complaint arrived.

D Recorded the issue in the lessons learned register at closure.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager have done to prevent this?

A Surface expectations early with prototypes.

A mobile demo in week two would have exposed the 'obvious' expectation.

B Tighter contract.

Protects legally but not the relationship. The customer is still disappointed.

C Add it free.

A reaction, not prevention, and uncontrolled scope.

D Lessons learned at closure.

Records the problem after it has cost the relationship.

THE SIGNAL

Requirements met, customer unhappy, 'it was obvious': an unstated expectation nobody surfaced.

> The head of sales wants a new customer portal launched in March with every planned feature. The head of operations wants a later launch, to allow full stability testing.
>
> Both have asked the project manager to plan around their preference.

What should the project manager do?

A Plan for the March launch, because sales generates revenue.

B Promise both: a March launch with full testing, by adding resources.

C Bring both together to examine trade-offs against the project objectives, so the decision-maker can choose.

D Escalate the disagreement to the chief executive.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Side with sales.

Quietly picks a side. Operations' valid concern is simply overruled.

B Promise both via more resources.

Overpromises. More people rarely compress testing without new risk.

C Examine trade-offs together; decision-maker chooses.

Facilitates alignment on objectives, perhaps a March MVP with a later full release.

D Escalate to the chief executive.

Premature. The two have not been brought together.

THE SIGNAL

Conflicting expectations: facilitate trade-offs against the objectives. Do not pick a side or promise both.

> During a routine check, the project manager finds that a developer has built two extra reporting features the customer never requested.
>
> The developer believes the customer will be delighted. The features took three days, and testing has not started on them.

What should the project manager do?

A Discuss it with the developer, assess the impact, and propose the features through the change process if they add value.

B Keep the features as a bonus for the customer.

C Tell the customer about the extras as a goodwill gesture.

D Remove the features immediately without discussing them.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Discuss, assess, route through change.
Handles gold plating properly, and still gives a good idea a fair hearing.

B. Keep as a bonus.
Gold plating accepted: untested code, and reset expectations.

C. Announce as goodwill.
Commits the project to supporting unrequested, untested work.

D. Remove without discussion.
Wastes the effort and the learning, and damages trust with the developer.

THE SIGNAL

Unrequested extras are gold plating. Talk, assess, and route good ideas through the proper channel.

> The project sponsor has missed three steering committee meetings in a row. Two decisions that need her approval are now overdue, and the team is waiting.
>
> Her assistant says she is very busy with a merger.

What should the project manager do?

A Make the two decisions, since the team cannot wait.

B Escalate the sponsor's absence to her manager.

C Meet the sponsor, even briefly, to agree how she can engage, such as delegating decisions within set limits.

D Cancel the steering committee until the merger is complete.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Make the decisions.
Acts beyond authority. The decisions are the sponsor's.

B Escalate to her manager.
Goes over the sponsor's head before speaking to her.

C Meet her; agree a workable engagement.
Addresses the risk directly, and adapts to her real constraints.

D Cancel the committee.
Removes governance while decisions are already overdue.

THE SIGNAL

A disengaged sponsor is a risk. Raise it with the sponsor first, and adapt the engagement to reality.

> A key supplier has just told the project manager that a component will arrive late, which will push the go-live back about three weeks.
>
> The next steering committee is in two weeks. The project manager would like to present a full recovery plan at that meeting.

What should the project manager do?

A Wait for the steering committee, and present the delay with a full recovery plan.

B Inform key stakeholders now of what is known, and when recovery options will follow.

C Tell only the project team until the recovery plan is ready.

D Keep the delay quiet while trying to recover the time.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Wait two weeks with a full plan.
Tempting, but stakeholders may hear it elsewhere, and lose two weeks to plan.

B. Inform now; say when options follow.
No surprises: early, factual, and with a clear next step.

C. Team only.
Keeps decision-makers uninformed about a material change.

D. Keep it quiet.
Hides a known problem. A breach of honesty and trust.

THE SIGNAL

Material bad news goes out early, even without a full plan. Say what is known and when you will know more.

> An agile team delivers a working increment every two weeks, and the product owner is very satisfied with progress.
>
> Meanwhile, support tickets from end users are rising, and usage data shows most users abandon the new workflow halfway through.

What should the project leader do?

A Rely on the product owner's satisfaction, since the product owner represents the users.

B Ask the team to add more features to make the product more attractive.

C Escalate the support tickets to the sponsor.

D Gather direct feedback from end users and share the usage data with the product owner to adjust the backlog.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Trust the product owner's view.

The data says the users disagree. A proxy can drift from the people it represents.

B Add more features.

More of what users already abandon. Treats a usability problem with scope.

C Escalate the tickets.

The product owner, who owns the backlog, has not even seen the data.

D Direct user feedback; data to the PO.

Monitors real customer satisfaction and lets the owner respond.

THE SIGNAL

Product owner happy, users struggling: measure the real customers, and give the owner the evidence.

Surface expectations early, align them openly, and never let anyone be surprised.